careful construction of a supporting narrative.[16] However, once a culture of violence is established, it becomes easier to escalate from discrimination to direct violence against individuals, and from there to large-scale attacks and murder.[17] In these circumstances, group differences don't just become more entrenched over time, but a situation can be created in which active conflict with the 'Other' becomes a key part of the identity of each ethnic or religious group. For example, can you be a true (Sunni) Muslim if you accept that the Shi'a also have a legitimate system of beliefs? Or, in our case, can you be a true Burmese if you are perfectly happy for Muslims to live in Myanmar?

If the answer to either question is no, then the only remaining debate is over how you should go about resolving the problem. While some would argue that there is still a need for dialogue (after all, these examples are differences related to chosen beliefs, not fundamental ethnicity), the reality is that exclusion of the 'Other' or even their complete destruction become 'acceptable' solutions, at least to some—and support for this sort of response can be increased by deliberate actions.

A key act in producing the conditions for genocide is slow legitimation and normalisation of the framework used to justify discrimination and murder on the basis of identity, and testing the limits of what is acceptable. Genocide requires the long-term development of the cultural and institutional conditions we have highlighted in order to organise and sustain such violence.[18] This takes real effort by those with power, and the development of the required conditions is unlikely in most settings. In reality, genocide has been rare, and one reason for this is that most situations cannot sustain the necessary ideological conditions for it to happen. People revert to living with their neighbours with some degree of give and take, and find out through interaction that those deemed to be 'Other' are actually not that fundamentally different from themselves.

In other instances, external powers may be able to intervene in localised communities to prevent a situation slipping out of control. Regional powers have often historically intervened to protect the interests of oppressed minorities in countries around them, as for example Iran often does today to further the interests of Shi'a groups all over the Muslim world. This logic has a long tradition of alleviating potentially genocidal situations, even if it can be destabilising in other respects.[19] And it also underpins the UN's